

**A Technology-Enabled Approach to Improving Access
to Mental Health Information Among Students in the
Philippines**

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I. Introduction

Mental health is an important part of students' overall well-being because psychological difficulties can affect their academic performance, relationships, daily functioning, and ability to cope with school-related demands. Students may experience concerns such as academic stress, anxiety, depression, lack of sleep, relationship problems, and difficulty adjusting to school. However, recognizing these concerns does not always mean that students know where to find reliable information or appropriate support.

A study by Serrano et al. (2023) involving 187 senior high school students in Metro Manila found that 82.89% of participants were at significant risk for anxiety, 60.96% were at significant risk for depression, and 25.67% were at significant risk for stress. The researchers emphasized the importance of strengthening social support and school mental-health programs for students at risk of poor mental health. These percentages describe the specific study population and should not be interpreted as representing all Filipino students.

The problem is not only the presence of mental-health concerns but also the difficulty some students experience in seeking appropriate help. A systematic review of Filipino help-seeking behavior found that barriers to formal mental-health services include financial constraints, inaccessibility of services, stigma, shame, and concerns about how mental-health problems are viewed socially. The review also found that Filipinos commonly prefer seeking support from family and friends.

Access to understandable and trustworthy mental-health information can therefore help students recognize common concerns, understand when support may be appropriate, and identify available services. The Department of Health's Mental Health Program also identifies increasing access to mental-health services, promoting mental well-being, strengthening community-based care, and reducing stigma as important objectives.

Students frequently use smartphones and digital platforms to access information, technology can provide a practical way to make mental-health information easier to find. Recent research involving Filipino college students demonstrated the feasibility of a digital mental-health literacy program that incorporated psychoeducational videos, online group forums, and self-help modules. Participants reported increased awareness and vocabulary concerning mental and emotional health, while experts found the program's content relevant and clear.

This project proposes MindWell PH, a student-centered digital mental-health information and support hub designed to make reliable mental-health information, educational materials, and pathways to appropriate support easier to access.

II. Identified Problem

The primary problem addressed by this project is the lack of easy access to reliable and understandable mental-health information among students.

Students may encounter mental-health information through social media, search engines, classmates, or other online sources. However, not all information available online is accurate, appropriate, or easy to understand. Students may also have difficulty determining whether what they are experiencing is related to ordinary school stress or whether they should consider seeking support.

Several barriers can contribute to this problem:

- **Lack of awareness** – Students may not know where to obtain reliable mental-health information.
- **Unreliable online information** – Social media may contain inaccurate or misleading mental-health claims.
- **Limited knowledge of available services** – Students may be unaware of school counselors, community services, or other appropriate support options.
- **Difficulty finding contact information** – Even when services exist, students may not know how to locate them.
- **Stigma and hesitation** – Students may feel uncomfortable asking others about mental-health concerns.
- **Accessibility barriers** – Distance, cost, and limited availability can make formal services difficult to reach.

These barriers show the need for a technology-based system that focuses not on diagnosing students but on improving mental-health literacy and connecting students with appropriate sources of support.

III. Solution

To address the identified problem, this project proposes MindWell PH, a web-based and mobile-friendly mental-health information and support hub for students. The platform would organize reliable mental-health information into a simple and accessible digital system. Instead of requiring students to search through multiple websites or social-media posts, the platform would provide several important functions in one place.

1. INFORM – Mental Health Information Center

The Inform section would provide simple, student-friendly educational materials about common mental-health concerns such as:

- Academic stress
- Anxiety

- Depression
- Sleep difficulties
- Emotional well-being
- Relationship concerns
- Adjustment difficulties
- Coping with school-related pressure

The information would be written in understandable language and reviewed using credible sources. The purpose would be to improve students' mental-health literacy rather than to provide a diagnosis.

2. LOCATE – Mental Health Service Finder

The Locate feature would help students find available mental-health services.

Users could search according to their location and type of support needed. Information could include:

- School guidance or counseling offices
- Community mental-health services
- Government health facilities
- Hospitals or clinics
- Other verified mental-health service providers

Each listing would provide available contact information, location, operating details when available, and a description of the service.

This feature directly addresses the problem of students knowing that they need help but not knowing where to go or whom to contact.

3. CONNECT – Support Pathways

The Connect feature would provide students with clear information about possible next steps when they want support.

For example, the platform could guide a student toward:

Student → Trusted Person → School Guidance/Counseling → Appropriate Mental Health Professional

The system would emphasize that digital information is not a replacement for professional assessment or treatment. Instead, it would help students understand how to reach appropriate support.

4. SEARCH – Verified Mental Health Resources

The Search feature would allow students to search for specific mental-health topics and be directed toward information from credible organizations and institutions.

Search results could prioritize sources such as the Department of Health, World Health Organization, schools, hospitals, and recognized mental-health organizations.

Each resource would include its source and date of review so that outdated information can be identified and updated.

IV. Conclusion

The lack of accessible and understandable mental-health information can make it difficult for students to recognize mental-health concerns and identify appropriate sources of support. Philippine research has documented significant risks of anxiety, depression, and stress among the senior high school students included in specific studies, while research on Filipino help-seeking has identified barriers such as service inaccessibility, financial limitations, stigma, and shame.

The proposed MindWell PH demonstrates how information technology can be used to address this problem. Through a mobile-friendly website, verified mental-health resources, a service locator, support pathways, searchable information, and QR-code access, students can have a more convenient way to obtain trustworthy information.

The project does not aim to diagnose students or replace psychologists, counselors, doctors, or other qualified professionals. Instead, it serves as an information and navigation tool that can complement existing school and community mental-health services. Through responsible implementation, regular content review, and coordination with credible institutions, MindWell PH can help make mental-health information more accessible to students and encourage informed and appropriate help-seeking.

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